



Wildfires

Just like the saying goes

Satvik Pandey | satvik@dgit.in

Forest fires are one of the most devastating ways in which nature expresses its wrath. Toxic gases are released into the atmosphere, wildlife gets severely affected, and people's belongings get destroyed. In the last few years, we have seen a lot of forest fires not only on foreign land but in our own backyard. Forest fires are a serious problem for India's forest cover and the well-being of individuals residing close to these areas. In this article, we bring you the recent findings and historical data about the effects and causes of wildfires and how, in India, things are poised to take a turn for the worse if not dealt with effectively.

INCREASING FREQUENCY

Forest fires today are primarily triggered by rapidly changing climate conditions. In 2020, Australia saw one of the worst instances of forest fires, and since then, there have been several severe instances across the globe. The United Nations Environment Pro-

gram published a report earlier this year titled, *Spreading like Wildfire: The Rising Threat of Extraordinary Landscape Fires*, in which they elaborated on the causes and effects of the increased instances of wildfires globally. The report called for the adaptation of a revised and ready action plan to combat wildfires.

The report stated that wildfires, instead of being a one-off natural calamity, have become a regular part of the seasonal calendars. Not a single continent on the planet apart from Antarctica is untouched by them. It also mentioned that climate change is not the only factor causing a steep rise in the number of wildfires. The report stated, "A wildfire results from a complex interaction of biological,

meteorological, physical, and social factors that influence the likelihood of a wildfire breaking out, its propagation and intensity, duration and extent, and its potential to cause damage to economies, the environment, and society."

Given that the factors affecting wildfires, especially the climate and land management practices, are rapidly getting worse, so is the risk of wildfires. The report showed that by the end of the century, the risk of wildfires would increase by a "factor of 1.31 to 1.57" due to the contribution of multiple factors.

WHAT ABOUT INDIA?

The numbers stated above may not directly represent the situation in India. But, it does not look promising for India as well. As per the numbers published on the official website of the Forest Survey of India, there were "52,785 forest fires were detected using MODIS (Moderate Resolution Imaging Spectro-radiometer) sensor, and 3,45,989 forest fires were detected using SNPP-VIIRS (Suomi-National Polar-orbiting Partnership - Visible Infrared Imaging Radiometer Suite) in forest fire season from Nov 2020 to June 2021."

In the first three months of 2022, there were 1,36,604 recorded instances of forest fires in the country. These have led to a loss of human and animal life and a stark reduction in the cover of the lush green forest.

The future does not look any better. As per FSI, forest fires have increased ten times in the last decade, and if things remain the same, we may see worse numbers being reported. About 22 per cent of India's forest cover is

